

Jewish Prayer During the Days of Judgment

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Harav Ben Şion Me'ir Hai Ouziel

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Translation: Simon Montagu*

Throughout the whole of our secular life we are plunged in the depths of a dark and murky valley, in the battlefield of life with all its vicissitudes and conflicts. A voice cries out in defeat: the voice of the weak and destitute, physically and mentally oppressed by the tyrannous and the wicked, saying "Surely there is no fear of God in this place, and they will kill me"¹. Another voice cries out in triumph: the voice of those with confidence in their strength and power who reign in terror over those who are weaker than they are – "the wicked encircle the righteous and thus justice is perverted."²

There is no curse more dreadful and terrible than the lack of reverence for God. It is the cause of carnage and destruction, of rage and constant anguish, of the fear and mortal terror of man's domination of his fellow man which we saw in all its ghastliness in the last war, and which continues to inflict its blows on the remnants of the Jewish people who survived slaughter and persecution – many thousands of whom are still experiencing suffering, oppression, famine and wasting away in camps in the lands of persecution.

The House of God

In this dark world the Jewish people in all the countries of their dispersion found one sweet and precious corner full of the light of the Holy

¹ Genesis 20:11

² Habakkuk 1:4

One of Israel: the synagogue where they gathered every day, morning and evening, and on every Shabbat and Holy Festival; where they found a place filled with awe and with hope for the world; where they said in the words of our Father Jacob, our holy ancestor: “How awesome is this place! This is none other than the house of God, and this is the gate of Heaven!”³

When the Jewish people came together in this place, where the Holy Presence of the God of Israel dwells, they rose above the darkness of this world into a world where there was only light; their soul and spirit were united with the God of Israel and they said, “Surely the Lord is in this place! Surely God’s presence dwells in this place, and God’s hidden light shines out from it on all creation in all its forms.” Out of this sensation of pure and simple reverence for God their spirit rallied, their soul regained its strength, and they spoke out in joy and trembling: “You are awesome from your sanctuaries, O God, the God of Israel; it is he that gives strength and power unto his people. Blessed be God.”⁴

In this respect the synagogue is the spring of living water from which in every age and every period, in every situation, in all the scattered dispersions of their exile, the Jewish people drew the strength and power to endure and to accept all their troubles and tribulations with love and grace and continue with full, fresh and youthful strength and a supreme spiritual heroism unequalled in any nation or realm. They went on affirming their living commitment to their unique mission: to illuminate the world with the light of the true God and the light of Israel’s Torah, a Torah of life and judgement for Israel and all the nations.

3 Genesis 28:17

4 Psalm 68:36

The House of Judgement

The synagogue is sacred on every day of the year, since it emanates reverence and awe of holiness, as well as trust and hope in the redemption of the Jewish people.

It is seven times more sacred and awesome on the days of judgement, the ten days of repentance that begin on the first day of the seventh month. Isaiah wrote "Seek the Lord while He is present, call upon him when He is near",⁵ and our sages commented "These are the ten days from Rosh Hashana to Yom Kippur".⁶ They also said "Where is he present? In synagogues and houses of study. Where is He near? In synagogues and houses of study. And what is more, he stands over them, as it is written 'God stands in the congregation of the mighty, he adjudicates among the judges.'⁷"⁸ These two interpretations are connected, because the synagogues and study halls, the place where God's presence dwells, are the place of nearness where we become closer to the awe of God. That is the true closeness connecting the Jewish people with their Father in Heaven, as the psalm says, "It is good for me to draw near to God",⁹ and as Ibn Ezra comments, "That is true goodness". That is what the sages meant when they wrote "Where is He close? In the synagogues and houses of study."

This presence and nearness of God is at its peak during the days of judgement, when all created beings, and especially the Jewish people, come before the judgement throne of the God who is sanctified by righteousness; the days when the synagogues and houses of study that are dedicated to Torah, to prayer, and to repentance are transformed into the King of justice's house of judgement. Thus he is not only pre-

5 Isaiah 55:6

6 Rosh Hashana 18a

7 Psalm 82:1

8 Yerushalmi Berachot 5:1

9 Psalm 73:28

sent and near, but standing over them: “God stands in the congregation of the mighty, he adjudicates among the judges”.

There are two aspects of this sublime awe: awe of the God of Truth, who permeates all worlds and is the moving force of all worlds, who watches and sees the actions of every person and repays everyone according to their deeds and the thoughts of their heart; and awe of the judgement sanctified by righteousness, through which he is elevated and uplifted: “The Lord of hosts is exalted by judgement and the holy God is sanctified by righteousness.”¹⁰ This awe raises us to a supreme level of knowledge of the True God: “Know this day and take it to heart, that the Lord is God.”¹¹ It leads us to connect to God and to follow in his ways: “As he is merciful, do you be merciful; as he is gracious, do you be gracious ...”¹² And these two aspects are really one, as Jeremiah says: “Let him that takes pride take pride in this, that he understands me and knows me, that I am the Lord who exercises lovingkindness, judgement and righteousness in the world, for these are things in which I take pleasure, says the Lord.”¹³ This awe becomes more intense in both its aspects during the days of Judgement: it fills our soul with joy and bliss and unites us with our Father in Heaven, the One Eternal God, as Nehemiah, Ezra the scribe, and the Levites who interpreted the Torah said to all the people: “Do not grieve, for the joy of the Lord is your strength”.¹⁴ This pure awe brings the heart and soul towards the love of God, as our sages said: “My awe stems from my joy, my joy stems from my awe, and my love is the greatest of all”¹⁵. Through the light of this sublime awe, which flickers from the human soul, the candle of the Lord,¹⁶ and from the holiness of God’s presence, which dwells within

¹⁰ Isaiah 5:16

¹¹ Deuteronomy 4:39

¹² Shabbat 133b

¹³ Jeremiah 9:24

¹⁴ Nehemiah 8:10

¹⁵ Eliyahu Rabba chap. 3

¹⁶ Proverbs 20:27

us and lights up our gloomy darkness, we answer God's voice when it calls us, saying "Return unto me and I will return unto you."¹⁷

As this voice calls on us to awake, we run, young and old, in trembling and loving longing, to the synagogue – to the house of God – to His house of judgement – enfolded in awe, in a tallit of sanctity, lifting up our hearts towards the holy sanctuary and the ark of the covenant, towards the throne of judgement, repeating the words of prayer and of praise which are the heritage passed down to us from our ancestors unto all generations. In heartfelt prayer we pour out our sorrows before our Father in Heaven, bewailing our long-drawn out suffering even as we pray to him and plead for our redemption and liberation.

The liturgy of the day

The Rosh Hashana services are unique among all the Shabbat and Festival services, in their content, in their form, in the melodies that are so appropriate to the holiness and reverence of the day, and in the sounding of the Shofar with its rousing, terrifying, strengthening and comforting call.

There is a common thread running through the whole service, a thread made up of three strands:

- 1) The sanctity of God: "You are holy and your name is awesome, and there is no God except for You, as it is written 'The Lord of Hosts is exalted in judgement, and the Holy God is sanctified in righteousness'¹⁸. "When the Holy One, Blessed be He, executes judgement on his world he is fearsome, elevated, and praised."¹⁹
- 2) The establishment of the world under the rule of the Almighty: "Reign over the whole world in your glory and be lifted up over the whole earth in your splendour ... and let everyone with breath in his

¹⁷ Malachi 3:7

¹⁸ Isaiah 5:16

¹⁹ Zephaniah 1:5b

lungs say “The Lord the God of Israel is King, and his kingdom rules over all.’ ”

3) The redemption of Israel, which is the redemption of the Shechina: “O Lord our God, may you rule swiftly over all your works on Mount Zion, your glorious sanctuary, and in Jerusalem the city of your temple, as is written in your holy writings ‘The Lord shall reign for ever, your God, O Zion unto all generations. Praise the Lord!’²⁰”

This passage concludes with a sentence which is short, but contains great depth and breadth: “And your word, our King, is true and everlasting.”²¹ The meaning of this sentence is not obvious, because it does not say explicitly what is meant by “your word”. Our rabbis disagreed about its meaning, and this disagreement led to differences in the text. The “Mordechai”²² writes that it refers to the verse “Your word stands firm in heaven”:²³ if You judged humanity with strict justice, they would not remain in existence even for a moment, as the verse says “On the day that you eat from it you will surely die”²⁴, but you judge them with mercy, and you have instructed them to judge their children with mercy. The “Kol Bo”²⁵ interprets “your word” to mean “your promise”: you promised us many times that you would redeem us and that you alone would reign, and therefore we pray to you to fulfil your words, since your word is true and everlasting.²⁶

According to both of these interpretations, it would have been sufficient to finish with the words “Your word is true and everlasting”, and indeed R. Moses Isserles writes “we conclude ‘Your word is true and

²⁰ Psalm 146:16

²¹ Tur OH 582

²² Commentary on the Talmud by Mordechai ben Hillel Hacohen (Germany, ca. 1250–1298)

²³ Psalm 119:89

²⁴ Genesis 2:17

²⁵ Anonymous halachic compendium, Provence, 14th century

²⁶ Beit Yosef *ad loc.*

everlasting' ”²⁷, which is also the text given by the RaMBaM²⁸, but our teacher the HIDA²⁹ writes “our custom is to say: ‘Your word, *our King*, is true...’; this seems to have been the ARI’s version”³⁰, and it is also the version in Sefer Ḥasidim (chapter 258). In this version, it means: “your word, when you said you would be our King, is true and everlasting”, as in the verse “I am the Lord, your Holy One, the Creator of Israel, your King”³¹, or “Thus says the Lord the King of Israel and his redeemer, the Lord of Hosts”³²: the kingship of God which is unique to the Jewish people has not deserted them and never will desert them, and this is what will bring the knowledge of God and his kingship to the whole world, as in Daniel’s vision of the end of days: “And the kingdom and dominion, and the greatness of the kingdom under the whole heaven, shall be given to the people who are the holy ones of the most High, whose kingdom is an everlasting kingdom”³³ or the Jewish people’s proclamation, “For the Lord is our judge, the Lord is our lawgiver, the Lord is our king; he will save us.”³⁴

This is the same message that is implicit in the closing words of the blessing said on the days of remembrance and judgement: “Your word, our King, is true and everlasting”, like the words recited in the blessing of redemption after the Shema: “It is true that You are the Lord our God and the God of our fathers, our King and the King of our fathers, our Rock and our Redeemer...”

And this is the essence of the liturgy on the days of judgement. This sublime prayer uplifts the soul and the spirit to the Throne of Glory of

²⁷ ReMA on Shulḥan ‘Aruch *ad loc.*, section 8

²⁸ See Mishne Torah, Seder Tefillot and Hilchot Shabbat 29:20

²⁹ Ḥaim Yosef David Azulai, 1724–1806

³⁰ Birkei Yosef *ad loc.* section 11

³¹ Isaiah 43:15

³² Isaiah 44:6

³³ Daniel 7:27

³⁴ Isaiah 33:22

the Presence of the God of Israel, which is the Throne of Judgement of the world's only God and Judge.

In this context of spiritual elevation, the Shofar's call is heard, calling to mind two sublime and eternal memories:

- 1) The Binding of Isaac, which is literally reenacted for Isaac's descendants in every generation and in every age, providing a faithful testimony of Israel's glory and the presence of God's kingship within them, as in the verse "The Lord their God is with them and the trumpet call of a king is among them."³⁵ This royal fanfare emerges from the depths of the Jewish soul, which is imprinted with His royal seal, radiating royal glory and pride upon their faces and their actions, even as they are bound or their bodies are consigned to the flames.
- 2) The memory of the Revelation of the Torah on Mount Sinai, when the sound of the Shofar was heard with great power, terrifying the whole world then and ever since, and causing all other sounds to fall silent before it.

These associations of the days of remembrance and judgement are recalled in words and in actions in the synagogue: in prayer, in admonition, and in the sound of the Shofar. They are the Jewish people's Defence Counsel before the throne of judgement. They summon us all to repentance, to stand again below Mount Sinai, where our ancestors proclaimed: "All that the Lord has said, we will obey and we will listen."³⁶ Let us listen to the sound of the Shofar and make the same proclamation: we will obey and we will listen. We will obey all God's commandments, and we will listen to the words of His Torah, since study leads to action. And may it be in our favour that we obey all the commandments that God gave us, so that we merit to hear the sound of the Shofar of redemption, as Isaiah writes: "In that day it shall happen that the great Shofar shall be sounded, and those who are in peril in the

³⁵ Numbers 23:21

³⁶ Exodus 24:7

land of Assyria, and those who are outcasts in the land of Egypt, shall come and bow down before the LORD in the mountain of the sanctuary: in Jerusalem.”³⁷

I will conclude with a blessing: May all the House of Israel be written and sealed for a good year, for a good life of peace and tranquillity, for a year that will see the redemption of Israel in their land and in their state, and the rebuilding of Jerusalem.

37 Isaiah 27:13